DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Two Kinds of Blessing: Why Does Shabbat Feed the Week?

Daat Tevunot §160

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §160 (continued; section 8, part 5, end of section 8) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 28 September 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

We are on page 526, in the middle of §160, section 8, part 5. Before Yom Kippur we learned what the Shekhinah is and why there are different levels of holiness in different places and times. One final point completes the section.

Holiness you are born with

The Sekhel says there is one more essential matter: Knesset Yisrael has a root of holiness that belongs to the whole nation simply because it is Israel. Even the wicked of Israel share it. You did not earn it. You were born with it.

The Rabbi noted that this is where the Rambam and the Ramhal differ, as we saw at length in Derech Hashem. For the Rambam, nobody is born with virtue; a Jew may be born with more propensity, but he must earn it. For the Ramhal and the Kabbalah, a Jewish soul is a different identity, connected to the Jewish nation.

Given, taken away, then earned

Many things in life, said the Rabbi, are given freely and then taken away so that we work to earn them. The classic example is the night of Pesah. The shefa of that night is unparalleled, more than any other night including Yom Kippur. That is why it is the only night treated as day, the only night on which we say Hallel. By morning it is gone, and we have seven weeks to work our way back. Feel it, experience it, then go and earn it.

He gave two more examples. In a relationship, the first flush of romance is unearned and does not last. There is no Hebrew word for romance; whenever modern Hebrew simply borrows the English word, it means there is no Jewish concept for it. The problem is that people expect to live on that level forever. When it fades they either break up or realise they have to work. "Every relationship you have to work on." And a child is conceived in a moment, then formed over nine months.

Primary and secondary existence

The Ramhal says that although this inborn holiness is rooted in very lofty things, the day to day events of our lives do not depend on it. They depend on our deeds. So there are two aspects:

- **The primary aspect.** It depends on our work. It is less lofty, but it is the critical one: the world runs according to it.
- **The secondary aspect.** It is unearned, simply because we are Jews. It is very lofty, but it does not play the main part in how life runs.

Participants found the terms confusing, since the "secondary" one is the higher. The Rabbi clarified: "secondary" means not critical. The primary is critical, less lofty, and has to be worked for. The secondary is higher, less critical, and comes by itself.

Three ways to see Shabbat

Section 10 will discuss time, but the Ramhal introduces it here. The Rabbi gave three ways of looking at Shabbat:

1. **The end of the week.** Six days of work, and on the seventh we rest as God rested.
2. **The middle of the week.** From Wednesday we begin preparing for Shabbat, and until Tuesday its holiness lingers, which is why Havdalah can be made until then.
3. **The source of the week.** As the Zohar says, from Shabbat all the days of the week are blessed. Each week draws its existence and shefa from the Shabbat before it.

This explains Melaveh Malkah, the fourth meal, which carries the holiness of Shabbat into the week, and Isru Hag, "binding" the festival to the day after. Mosei Shabbat still has a remnant of holiness, and some halachot reflect that.

Why the morning matters most

In the same way, the main part of each day is the morning. The Ramhal's note sums it up: the principal influx of the week comes down on Shabbat, and the principal influx of each day comes down in the morning. These primary influxes are received through the primary aspect of our existence, what we work for. The rest of the day, afternoon and evening, receives the secondary influxes, which complete and finish off the day.

A participant pointed out that this explains why Shaharit is so much longer than Minhah and Arvit. Shaharit needs real work; Arvit comes almost by itself. In Kabbalistic thought the morning is always the focus. Courts judge only by day, sacrifices are offered by day, and there are things one avoids doing at night.

The Rabbi applied it to life. People who work hard when they are young find the rest of life easier. If you miss the morning, the rest of the day is hard. You cannot then sleep through the afternoon; you still need a short prayer and a bit of work later on. But the foundation is laid in the morning.

He spoke of praying at netz, sunrise, which is hard in England because the time changes so much, and brought the Gemara in Berakhot about one who would pray at netz and laugh all day: he had established himself properly in the morning. A participant added that it is the quality of the morning prayer that sets the tone, not just turning up and reading.

The Kohanim and the end of section 8

Just as there are higher and lower levels of holiness in the sacrifices, there are levels of shefa. The Kohanim had to know which shefa they were dealing with at each time, and what was needed for that time.

The Rabbi then read the closing paragraph of section 8 (page 532). We have seen the nature of the sustaining force; how it relates to the emanations acting upon the world; how it relates to the lower worlds through the Shekhinah; the partnership of the righteous with God; and finally the two aspects of that force as reflected in the two aspects of the Jewish people.

For homework over Sukkot: read the summary of section 8 (pages 534-540) and the brief summary of all eight sections (pages 653-663). After Sukkot we begin section 9, which explains how the tikkun haklali happens by itself in the background.

Summary

- The Jewish people have an inborn holiness that does not depend on their deeds; the Rambam and the Ramhal differ on whether such a thing exists.
- Like the night of Pesah, some gifts are given freely, then withdrawn so we earn them.
- The primary aspect of our existence depends on our work and runs the world; the secondary, loftier aspect is unearned and completes things.
- Shabbat is the source of blessing for the whole week, and the morning is the source for the whole day; both are drawn down through our own work.
- This closes section 8, on the force that sustains existence.

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